The What Matters Most Meeting Checklist

What to ask, write down and leave open before the family decides.

There's a care decision to make for your loved one, and the family is getting together to talk about it. Before anyone compares options, see that these have been asked and written down. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is a conversation still to have, not a verdict on your family.

Ask

- [ ] Ask your loved one what matters most to them right now: what a good day looks like, what they'd hate to lose, what worries them. [1]
- [ ] Ask what they want in the decision that's coming. Ask now, even if you think you already know.
- [ ] Ask each relative involved the same three questions: What are you most worried about? What outcome do you hope for? What can you realistically do yourself?
- [ ] Ask the relatives who haven't said much. They get the same questions and the same room to answer as the one who talks most. [2]
- [ ] Ask your loved one, where it's possible, whether what you wrote down for them is right, and change what they say isn't.

Write down

- [ ] The decision that needs to be made, in one plain sentence, with its date if it has one.
- [ ] What your loved one has said, in their own words, kept apart from what the family believes they want.
- [ ] The routines and choices they want to keep: the morning coffee on the porch, their own kitchen, the Sunday phone call.
- [ ] Where the family already agrees.
- [ ] Where expectations conflict, in wording each person would call fair.
- [ ] What each relative has said they can and cannot realistically do.

Leave open

- [ ] Any disagreement that hasn't settled. Write it down as it stands. Nobody has to give in for the page to be complete.
- [ ] The questions that need a doctor, a nurse or another professional, each with the name of the relative who will ask.
- [ ] Comparing options, places or services. That comes after the family can see what matters, to your loved one and to each other.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you ask and write down. It doesn't say who is right, what a checked or unchecked box means, or what the family should choose. That takes your loved one, the whole family, and the next step below.

Ready for the next step?

You've asked, and you've written down what was said. The care interview adds the other half: it walks you through your loved one's situation area by area, so what matters to them sits beside a full picture of what the decision is about, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The item marked 1 follows the National Institute on Aging's advice to ask the person directly. The item marked 2 follows the Family Caregiver Alliance's point that a family meeting should give everyone a chance to be heard. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting

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